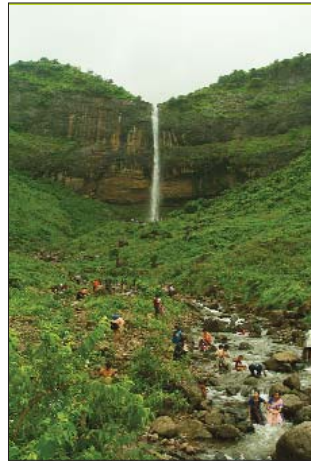




An example of an underexposed picture. If you shot a picture like this one, don't worry...



...you can bring it back to life using Photoshop's Opacity setting, as described in this article

☑ Learn about Depth of Field (DOF). DOF is essentially the range of distance that is acceptably sharp within a photo. It varies inversely with the aperture size. For example, a wide-open lens with an aperture of f1.8 has very little DOF. If it is squeezed to f16, the DOF increases, and more things come into focus.

☑ In macros, the DOF is especially shallow. Here is an example on getting a good macro shot: if the subject is a fly on a flower, use a larger aperture—this will blur out everything but the fly. If you want the fly as well as the flower, you will need a larger DOF; so a small aperture—f11, or even f16—is required. This, however, makes longer exposure periods necessary, which in turn calls for steady hands. In other words, macros of small objects with the background blurred out are easy enough. However, if you want a macro of say, a flower, you need steady hands.

☑ In the example about the flower, you can compensate for exposure time by using a higher ISO (or ASO) setting, but this brings in the possibility of extra image noise.

Correcting pictures



Remember to back up your images before you start to correct or play around with them to create different effects!

☑ A colour cast means an imbalance of colour, such as too much red or too much

green. There are two methods to correct this in Photoshop: in the first, simply go to **Image > Adjust > Levels**. Here, click 'Auto'. In the second, go to **Layer > New Adjustment Layer > Color Balance**. Then, click OK to create the adjustment layer and bring up the 'Color Balance Layer' dialog box. Here, you can experiment. ☑ Underexposed pictures are a frequent problem: you need the correct level of light exposure to bring out detail. If an image turns out underexposed, here's what you can do in Photoshop:

If the whole image needs adjusting, go to **Windows > Show Layers**. In the Layer dialog box, locate the Layer thumbnail. Drag it to the 'Create A New Layer' icon to duplicate the image. To only fix certain underexposed areas, go to step 2, else skip to step 3.

Select the affected areas using the Marquee tool. Go to **Select > Feather**, and type in, say, '5' in the numerical field to soften this section by a few pixels. You can experiment with that value. Now, copy and paste to create a duplicate layer.

In the drop-down menu of the Layer dialog box, select **Screen**.

Adjust the density of this layer in the Opacity field until you get the required density.

☑ Here's how you selectively sharpen certain areas of a photograph in Photoshop: **Select Filter > Sharpen > Unsharp Mask**. In the dialog box that comes up, experiment with the three sliders—Amount, Radius and Threshold. View the results in the preview window. The Radius setting is the key here. It controls the width of the sharpening halo. The Amount controls the sharpening strength. A small Radius setting needs a higher Amount.

Finally, set the Threshold—this helps avoid over-sharpening light-textured areas such as skin tones. Start with an Amount of 200 to 300 per cent and a Threshold of 0, and experiment with the Radius setting until it matches the image contents. Then, adjust the Amount.

Finally, increase the Threshold to smoothen out over-sharpened areas.



This is a somewhat blurred picture. You may want to keep it this way, or you can ...



... use Photoshop's sharpening feature to bring out more detail

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